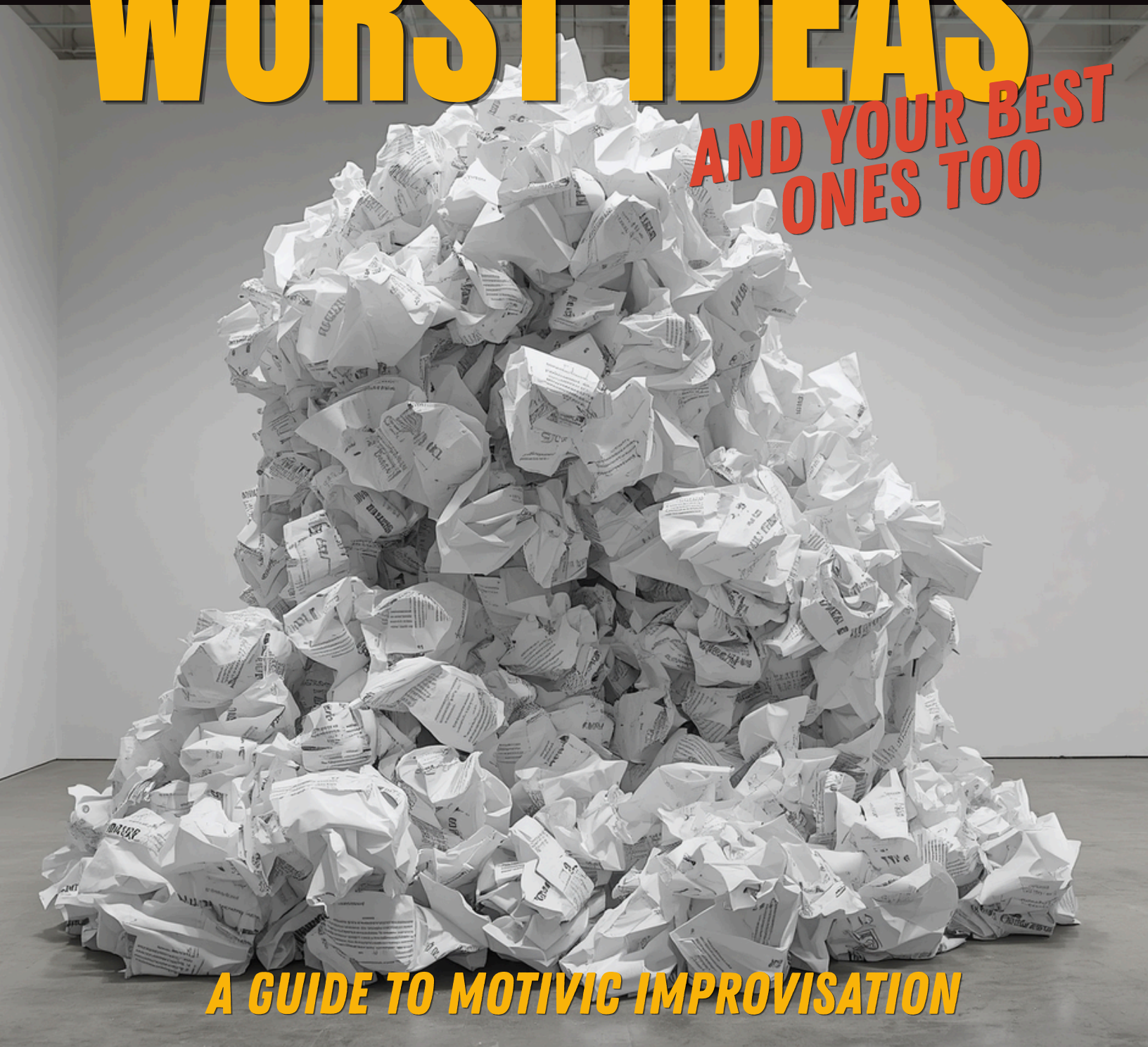
JAZZ LAB MUSIC

HENRIQUE EISENMANN AND TIM LIENHARD

REPEAT YOUR WORST IDEAS

AND YOUR BEST ONES TOO



A GUIDE TO MOTIVIC IMPROVISATION

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WHAT'S THE POINT?

We are all familiar with the idea of repeating your mistakes in jazz, but we wanted to dive a little deeper and understand how repetition is actually the point; it is the argument; repetition is permission. It transforms a mistake into a statement with intent.

REPETITION = INTENT



Very often in jazz improvisation we obsess with lines, long streams of notes, as if we need to showcase to the audience - and to the bandmates - our entire arsenal of ideas, scales, skills.

However, the most effective and beautiful solos are normally the ones that feature lots of repetitions, and a constant dialog with silence.

Repeating an idea is an act of generosity to your audience and to your band. It allows the listener to confirm an expectation, it enhances the power of the phrase, it allows the band to react and join the dialogue.

So how can we practice that?

Here are some ideas.....

HENRIQUE EISENMANN

THREE DOMAINS OF CREATIVITY



Arthur Koestler in *The Act of Creation describes 3 domains of creative ideas: Humor, Science and Art.*

HUMOUR	DISCOVERY	ART
comic simile	hidden analogy	poetic image
witticism	epigram	trouvaille
satire	social analysis	allegory
impersonation	empathy	illusion
caricature	schematisation	stylisation
pun	word-puzzle	rhyme
riddle	problem	allusion
debunking	discovering	revealing
coincidence	"trigger"	fate

Adapted from Koestler, A. 1964. The Act of Creation.

I like to think about these as the natural stages of evolution of any creative idea (regardless of the field). A creative idea starts as humor (a joke, a parody, a riddle, a mistake), which then evolves into science (understanding the reasons, the theory behind the initial idea), and eventually becoming art (the process isn't rational anymore, it's purely expressive/poetic).

This can serve as a good reminder of the importance of having a sense of humor when making music and experimenting: making parodies, exaggeration, jokes, imitations, games, etc. Those are essential for a creative practice.

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FREE PLAYING WITH REPEATS

Every musician should start their practice session by playing complete free: no rules, no limits, no judgment. Just throw your hands on your instrument and see what comes out of it. Try to push the boundaries, play atonal chords, clusters, angular melodies, extended techniques, unusual constrats. Your ears may complain, and your brain may start judging ("this is bull****"). Try to overcome these initial impulses. I recommend playing free for around 10 mins.

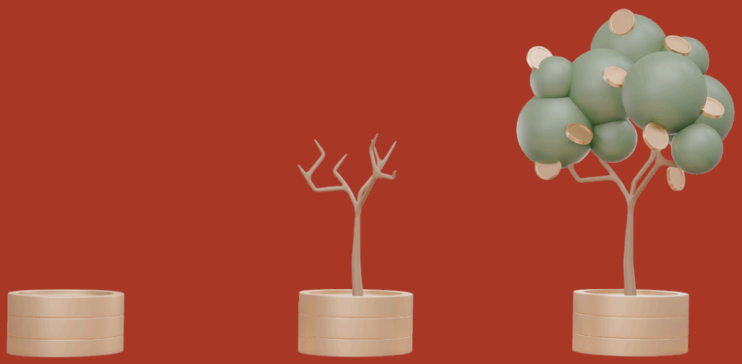
But there ONE rule you should follow:

EVERY IDEA THAT CAN BE REPEATED SHOULD BE REPEATED.

Repeat the chords, the gestures, the fragments of melody, the articulation. If you play a long phrase, try to repeat the last 2-3 notes.

You will start to be surprised how suddenly out of that chaos some structure will emerge. REPETITION is ARCHITECTURE.

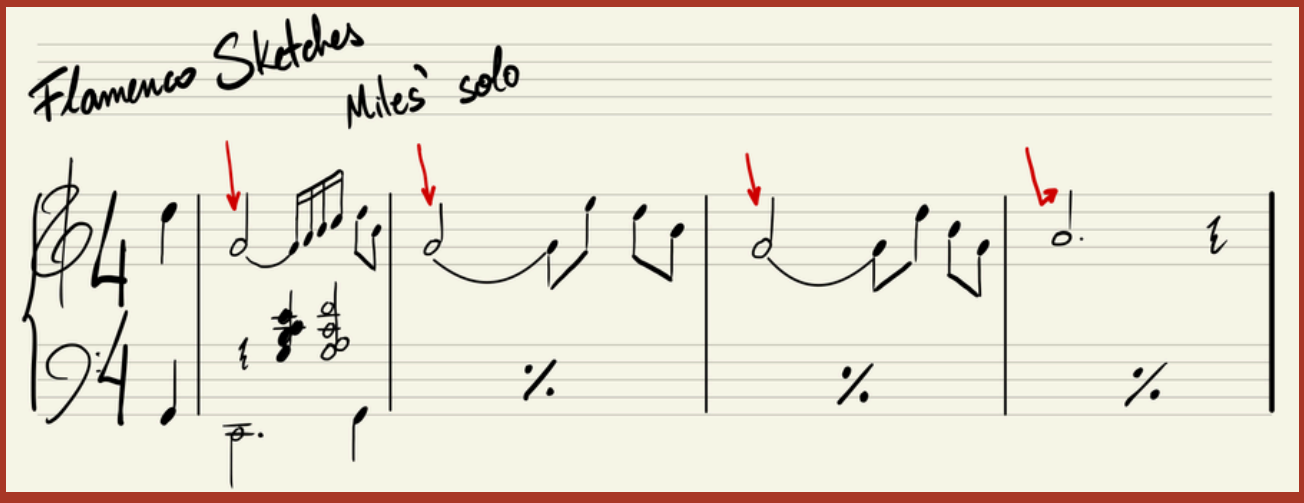




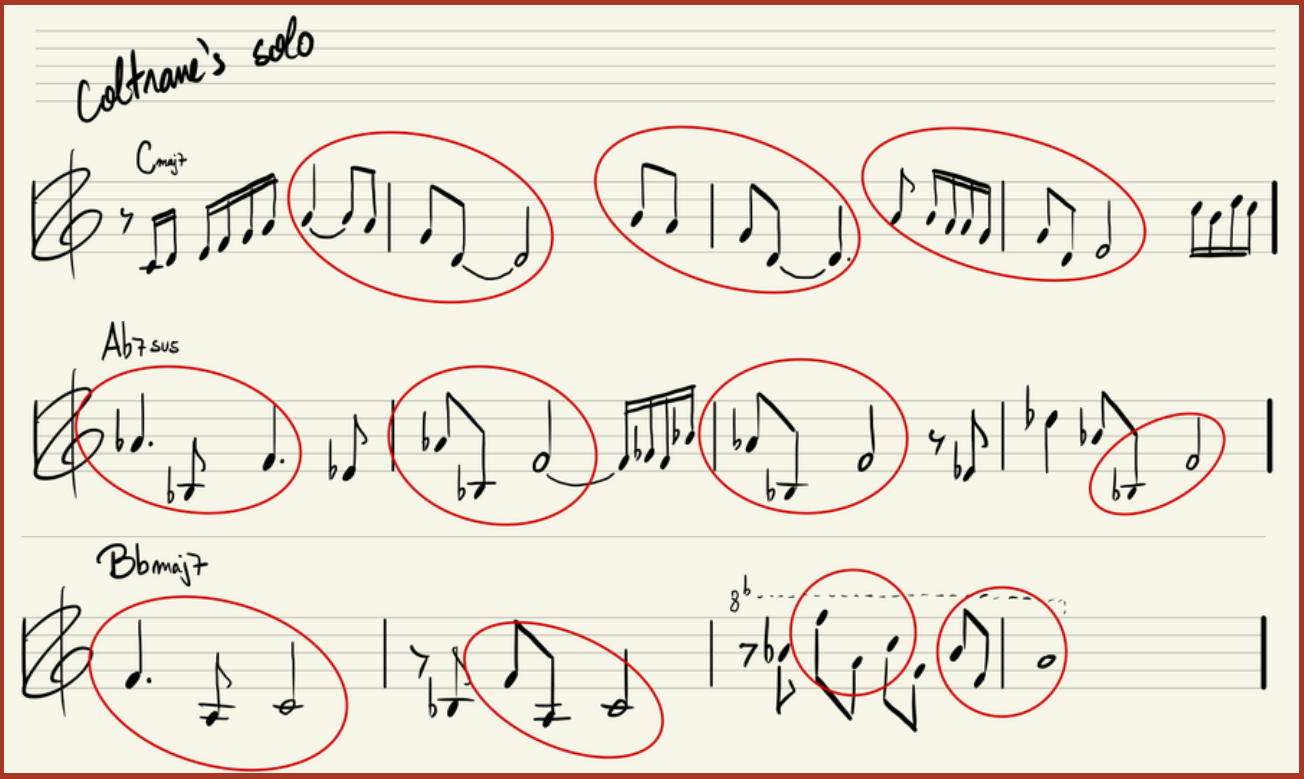
REPEAT AT LEAST 3 TIMES

Miles Davis' *Flamenco Sketches* from "A Kind of Blue" (1959) is one of the most spectacular masterclasses on repetition, motives, and dialog with silence.

The piece has no melody, just a sequence of 5 different modes over which each improviser takes a solo. Notice how Miles starts his solo by emphasizing the note G, and repeating 4 times a musical gesture that ends on G. On the last time, he gracefully ends on A to signify a conclusion of his first statement. Listen to the recording, and notice how simple it is.



Coltrane also embarks on a similar journey, repeating short 3-note motives three of four times on every new phrase.

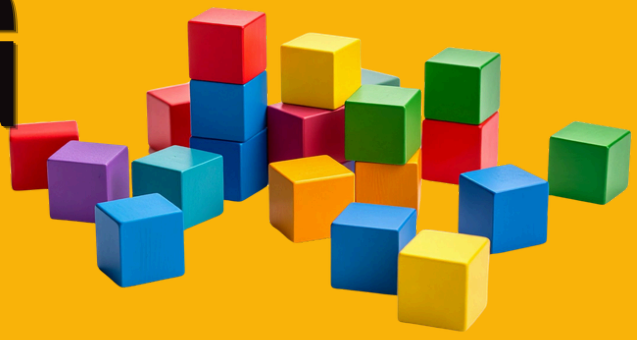


Surely enough, Coltrane and Miles both embellish the motives, displace them in the rhythmic grid, change the rhythm, and add a few passing tones and ornaments, but in essence thay are repeating the same idea.

Are these motives incredibly brilliant? No. Just like Beethoven's 5th Symphony's motiff, they are quite basic. But the way they are being repeated is absolutely phenomenal.

But are these repeated ideas "mistakes" or their "worst idea"? No. Miles and Coltrane are so intentional about their playing, that it's almost irrelavant to even talk about mistakes in their case.

CREATING MOTIVES

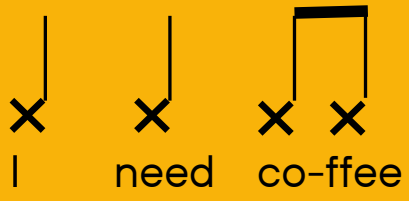


I often notice how students struggle to create simple motives. There is something frightening about creating a musical statement that is so short and simple. Inability to create good simple motives may lead to streams of never-ending phrases with no clear structure, like a confusing doodle.



Some jazz improvisation methods suggest thinking about direction: for example, choosing 3 notes in a specific direction (up-up, up-down, down-up, down-down).

Personally, I prefer to think about a musical gesture inspired by words. So I'll choose a word or short sentence, say it out loud and try to emulate the sound musically. For example, let's think of the sentence: "I need coffee!"; I will repeat it out loud a few times, until its rhythm becomes clear:



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This may seem like a simple motive, but all motives are simple, **THIS IS EXACTLY THE POINT**. The art is not on how complex the motive is, but how you build upon it.

Here are some different types of variations you can experiment:

- Try applying this rhyhtm to an ascending melody, or a descening melody.
- Try playing this rhythms in different parts of a measure (instead of starting on the downbeat).
- Try using some different larger intervals instead of diatonic notes. (Miles and Coltrane love 4ths and 5ths).
- Repeat each motive 3-4 times over a harmony and see if your ears can naturally find a resolution, a small change to the motive that gives a sense of conclusion.
- Try playing your motive as a rubato melody over a slow chord progression (maybe play it over Flamenco Sketches). Let the motive float over the accompaniment, as if you were a singer singing "I need Coffee" really slowly over a ballad.

